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TUESDAY, OCTOBER 27, 2026

Question 7 aims to revive starter homes

Would shrink the amount of land required to build a single-family house

By Andrew Brinker
GLOBE STAFF

NEWTON — Beethoven Avenue in this city's sought-after Waban neighborhood is not so different from other leafy street in Boston's well-to-do suburbs.

Sprawling multimillion-dollar houses have replaced the smaller, cheaper homes that dotted residential neighborhoods a decade or more ago.

But the transformation of streets like Beethoven Ave. illustrates a particularly vexing issue in the region's housing crisis: the disappearance of starter homes. The problem is fueled in part by local zoning rules in many communities that make it effectively illegal to build modest homes because they require large chunks of land to build a single house.

A group of advocates and planning professionals believes they have found a solution, with a ballot measure, Question 7, that could help revitalize middle-class homeownership in Massachusetts by shrinking the amount of land required to build a single-family house here.

It's a sound concept, homebuilders say. By allowing homes on smaller lots, builders may well be incentivized to build the more modest sort of houses that were widely accessible to first-time homebuyers in this state decades ago.

"You're basically taking a bunch of lots across the state that it didn't make sense to build

QUESTION 7, Page A10



PHOTO ILLUSTRATION BY LUIS G. RENDON/GLOBE STAFF; ADOBE

As costs soar, Healey shifts energy stance

Embrace of pipelines frustrates climate activists in run-up to election

By Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

In the midst of a contentious reelection campaign, nowhere was the metamorphosis of Governor Maura Healey's position on energy and climate change more evident than in the space of a single day in early October.

On that morning at an elementary school in East Boston, the governor gushed about the virtues of a clean energy project that, in her words, demonstrated "the work we can do together to protect our communities from climate change."

Then, not an hour later, her office sent out a press release with the title, "Governor Healey Calls on Trump Administration to Expedite Review of Gas Pipeline Expansion."

The dueling messages underscore how the first-term governor has distanced herself from an uncompromising environmental warrior of four years ago, when she proclaimed she would be the "most aggressive governor in the country on climate."

HEALEY, Page A6



THE 'MOST DANGEROUS' ROADS TO DRIVE IN BOSTON?

LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF

Riverway, Jamaicaway, and Arborway form a trifecta of jeopardy

By Billy Baker
GLOBE STAFF

They feel unlike any other roads in Boston, which was Frederick Law Olmsted's plan.

When he laid out the design of the Emerald Necklace, the string of parks that run like a serpent through the city from Boston Common to Franklin Park, he included three connected parkways that became known as the Riverway, the Jamaicaway, and the Arborway.

They were designed to immerse the traveler in nature via an intentionally curvy, tree-canopied, what's-around-the-next-bend jaunt on horseback or buggy. Because that's what they had in the 1880s.

Things have changed a lot since then. What hasn't changed are the curves of the three roadways. And today those curves — hemmed in by homes and development on one side and the Emerald Necklace on the other — serve as the main north-south corridor for a huge swath of city drivers. They are notoriously dangerous to drive, with lanes so narrow you feel like you need to hold your

EMERALD NECKLACE, Page A7

The Jamaicaway (above), along the Emerald Necklace, was designed to be a meandering parkway for horses or buggies, as were the Riverway and Arborway.

Apple crisp

Tuesday: Cooler but sunny. High 51-56. Low 35-40.
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Comics and Weather, **D7-8**

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Blue Cross cuts plans

Eliminating several Medicare Advantage options. **D1.**

Israelis will vote Tuesday in the first national elections since Hamas's Oct. 7, 2023, attack in what is seen as a referendum on Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's leadership. **A3.**

Multiple firefighters and residents were injured in Brockton as a five-alarm blaze tore through a triple-decker Monday. **B1.**

Families are turning to AI as a digital assistant to manage the spiraling administrative tasks of modern parenthood. **A2.**

In Farwell case, state investigation also on trial

Unusual dynamics as prosecutors challenge Mass. probe of Birchmore death

By Laura Crimaldi and Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

Just 12 minutes into Matthew Farwell's federal trial, the prosecution turned the jury's attention to the State Police investigation into Sandra Birchmore's death.

Detectives assigned to Norfolk District Attorney Michael W. Morrissey didn't treat the Canton apartment where Birchmore was found as a crime scene, the prosecutor said. They made crude comments about having to investigate at all, with one saying they "needed an investigation like they, quote, 'needed a [expletive] bullet in the head'," the prosecution told jurors.

The criticism laid bare the unusual dynamics for a criminal trial: The refusal of state investigators to pursue a criminal case against Farwell — and the FBI's reversal of that decision — which is now forcing federal prosecutors to both show not only that Farwell killed Birchmore, but also that state investigators got it wrong when they concluded Birchmore killed herself.

Jurors must decide: Which experts, investigators, and analysts to believe? How can prosecutors prove their case beyond a reasonable doubt after an earlier investi-

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JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

William Farwell (center), Matthew Farwell's brother, testified Monday he had a relationship with Sandra Birchmore. B1.